VELLUM PRESS

MINDFULNESS

Steady Mind

Short practices for stress



A DIGITAL GUIDE

Steady Mind

These are short practices for stress and attention. They are not therapy, and they are not a crisis service.

If a practice makes you more distressed, stop. If you might hurt yourself, contact local emergency services. In the United States, call or text 988.

> Wellness disclaimer. This guide is education, not psychotherapy, and not a crisis service. Mindfulness can sit alongside care. It does not replace it. Stop a practice that leaves you more distressed, and contact a licensed clinician if worry, panic, or low mood is persistent. If you might hurt yourself, contact local emergency services. In the United States, call or text 988.

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01

How to use this guide

Pick one practice and do it for a week before you collect more. The four-week plan is already short. Adding apps on top of it is how people avoid the ten minutes.

- One daily practice, ten minutes or less.
- A two-minute breath you can use in public.
- A stress log for one week so you can see the pattern.
- A stop rule if practice makes things worse.

02

A smaller definition of practice

Practice here means noticing what is happening and choosing one small response. It does not mean emptying your mind, adopting a belief, or feeling calm on command. Calm is sometimes a result. It is a poor requirement.

You can practice in a chair, on a bus, or in a parked car. You do not need a cushion, a special time of day, or an identity as someone who meditates. If the word meditation gets in the way, call it a pause.

03

Breath you can use in public

Physiological sigh: inhale through the nose, take a second short inhale to top it off, then a long slow exhale through the mouth. Do this three to five times. It is useful in a hallway because it is quiet and short.

Box breath, if you prefer counting: inhale four, hold four, exhale four, hold four, for one minute. If holding the breath makes you anxious, skip the holds and just lengthen the exhale. Longer exhales are the point for many people, not the performance of a count.

Practice	Time	Use when	Skip if
Sigh	Under a minute	You are spiked and in public	You feel lightheaded
Long exhale	Two minutes	Before a hard conversation	Breath focus panics you
Box	One minute	You like a count	Holds feel bad

> Stop if you feel dizzy, numb, or more panicked. Sit down. These are ordinary exercises, not tests of will.

04

A ten-minute body scan

Sit or lie down. Set a ten-minute timer so you are not watching the clock. Start at the feet. Notice contact, temperature, and effort, without trying to relax them on command. Move to the legs, the hips, the belly, the hands, the shoulders, the jaw, and the face. When attention leaves, bring it back to the last place you remember. That return is the practice.

A script you can read once and then paraphrase: 'Feet. Feel the floor. Legs. Notice weight. Belly. Let it move with the breath if that is easy. Hands. Shoulders. Unclench the jaw if you find it tight, or leave it and notice. Face. Then the breath at the nose for the last minute.'

> **Try this.** If lying down makes you dissociate or panic, do the scan seated with eyes open and a soft gaze on the floor. Eyes-closed is optional.

05

The stress log

For seven days, three times a day, write one line: time, what was happening, body signal, and what you did next. You are looking for the hour of the week that costs you, not for a theory of your personality.

Time	What was happening	Body	What I did
Morning			
Midday			
Evening			

At the end of the week, circle the repeating context. A practice aimed at that context beats a general promise to be calmer. If the log shows you are depleted because of workload or harm, the next chapter on boundaries matters more than a longer meditation.

06

Attention, phones, and boundaries

Attention is a place you return to, not a substance you store. The phone is a cue machine. Move the apps that fragment you off the first screen during the hours you named in the log. You do not need a new philosophy of technology. You need the first screen to match the hour.

A boundary is a sentence and a behavior. 'I do not answer work messages after 7' only works if you do not answer them. Scripts: 'I can do that tomorrow.' 'I am not available for that topic right now.' 'I need an hour before I decide.' Rest is not the same as avoidance. Avoidance shrinks your life. Rest has an end time and a return.

- One notification change tied to the log, not a total detox.
- One boundary sentence you will use this week.
- One recovery activity that is not a screen, scheduled.

07

Four weeks, written out

Week	Daily	Extra	Review
1	Two-minute exhale after one cue	Start the log	Which hour repeats
2	Keep the exhale. Add the body scan three days	Finish the log	Did the scan help or hurt
3	Scan or breath, plus one boundary sentence	Change one phone cue	Did the boundary hold
4	Keep the smallest practice that helped	Drop the rest	What you will continue

Week 4 is allowed to be smaller than week 2. A practice you keep is the result. A abandoned stack is not a moral failure.

08

When to reach past this PDF

Reach past it if distress is persistent, if you are not sleeping, if panic is narrowing your life, if substances are the main way you come down, or if you have thoughts of harming yourself. A licensed clinician is the right next person. This file can sit beside care. It cannot be care.

If you are in immediate danger, contact local emergency services. In the United States, call or text 988 for the Suicide and Crisis Lifeline. If a practice in this guide makes you feel worse, stop using it. That is a successful use of the guide.

> Nothing here diagnoses anxiety, depression, or trauma. Nothing here replaces medication or therapy that a clinician has recommended.

09

A worked example

H's hard hour was 4 p.m., between the last meeting and collecting a child. The log showed a tight jaw and a phone scroll, not a mysterious lack of mindfulness. Week 1 was a long exhale in the parked car, three times, before going inside. It did not make H calm. It made the next ten minutes less automatic.

The body scan on the couch at night, eyes closed, felt worse, not better. H stopped it. That was the correct use of the stop rule. The scan moved to a chair before breakfast, eyes open, four minutes. It was dull. Dull was acceptable.

Week 3 the boundary sentence was 'I will reply to that thread tomorrow.' H failed it twice and kept it anyway. The phone change was small: the work app left the first screen after 6 p.m. The stress log's repeating context got quieter. It did not disappear.

Week 4 kept the car exhale and dropped the longer scan to three days. A smaller practice that stayed was the result. H also had a therapist already. The PDF sat beside that care and did not pretend to replace it. On a worse week, H knew the number to call. The practice was never the crisis plan.

If your week does not look like this one, do not force the resemblance. Copy the structure: a baseline, one change at a time, a written review, and a stop when the tool is the wrong tool. The names above are teaching composites, not testimonials and not promises.

10

Field pages

Use the log for seven days before you decide the practice 'does not work.' One calm morning is not a pattern. One bad practice is a reason to stop that practice, not a reason to quit noticing.

Stress log

When	What was happening	Body signal	What I did next
Morning			
Midday			
Evening			
Morning			
Midday			
Evening			
Morning			

Four-week card

Week	Practice I kept	Did it help, hurt, or neither?	Boundary sentence
1			
2			
3			
4			

- [ ] I stopped any practice that made distress worse.
- [ ] One phone cue matches the hard hour in the log.
- [ ] I know who I would call if this PDF is not enough.
- [ ] If I am in crisis, I will use local emergency services or 988 in the United States.

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Thirty-day log

This log is the part you write. Print it. A guide you only read is a brochure. Thirty lines is a month, and a month is long enough to see whether the method fits.

Days 1 to 15

Day	Practice	Minutes	Hard hour	Helped?	Note
1					
2					
3					
4					
5					
6					
7					
8					
9					
10					
11					
12					
13					
14					
15					

Do not backfill a day you forgot. Leave it blank. A blank line is more useful next month than a number you invented. The lines are tall enough to write in, not just to type a checkmark.

Days 16 to 30

Day	Practice	Minutes	Hard hour	Helped?	Note
16					

Day	Practice	Minutes	Hard hour	Helped?	Note
17					
18					
19					
20					
21					
22					
23					
24					
25					
26					
27					
28					
29					
30					

Weekly notes

Week	What repeated	What I will change
1		
2		
3		
4		

Week	What repeated	What I will change
5		

Open notes

	Write in the lines

End of the month

Question	Your answer
What actually repeated?	
What did I abandon, and should it stay abandoned?	
What is the one change for next month?	

Question	Your answer
Do I need a person, not a PDF?	
Where is the file saved on my own device?	

- ☐ I can find this PDF without the download link.
- ☐ The license is mine. I have not posted the file.
- ☐ Next month's first action is written in one sentence.
- ☐ If the guide was the wrong tool, I know what I will do instead.

A last word

Use the pages that match the week you are actually having. Print a worksheet if paper helps you tell the truth. Put the file somewhere you can find it. And if a chapter tells you to talk to a licensed professional, that instruction outranks the rest of the PDF.